instruments act as tools to undermine the sovereignty of former colonies, with the ‘international’ community or the West acting as the Big Brother.

Interestingly, none of these instruments address the thorny subject of evangelical attempts to convert ‘tribal’ populations to Christianity, which ought to have been fairly obvious given the history of the Americas and other regions. Ironically, while the ‘dominant’ national majorities are expected to respect the identities of ‘indigenous peoples’, there is no international commitment to prevent external actors, such as missionary groups, from interfering with the course of indigenous life in the name of ‘educating’ or ‘civilising’ them. This proves that coloniality of international law itself needs to be revisited before reviewing instruments that relate to the rights of indigenous peoples. None of this is to take away from the fact that the declaration does indeed attempt to legitimise and ensure equal treatment of indigenous peoples. However, that it limits the scope of its vision exclusively to the creation of safe spaces for ‘indigenous peoples or the indigenous identity’ (a category which in itself warrants serious revision), as opposed to delinking their destinies from coloniality altogether, remains a fundamental limitation that overshadows incremental recognition of all other rights.

Having discussed the pith and marrow of the legal position on indigenous peoples, it becomes important to understand the colonial and modern nature of ‘development’, which is one of the most powerful social, cultural and political forces in the world today that affects indigenous ways of life. This is especially relevant to former colonies which were categorised as ‘under-developed’ or ‘developing’ following decolonisation.[29] The work of Colombian-American anthropologist Arturo Escobar in this regard is particularly arresting because he highlights the fact that this convenient categorisation by the West succeeded in creating the impression that former colonies were always ‘backward’ while the ‘West’ has always been a beacon of reason, progress and scientific temper.[30] The irony of former colonies becoming ‘recipient countries’ and the colonisers—the ‘developed’ ‘modern’ Western imperialists—becoming ‘donor countries’ is not lost on him. From positions on respect for nature to the rights of indigenous peoples to practising their ways of life, everything is affected by modern conceptions of ‘development’ in former colonies that aspire to Westernisation instead of identifying their own goals based on indigenous